



Rajeev Tyagi

Vishal Maheshwari
Head, Yahoo! India Mobile

“Yahoo! India does not believe in unsolicited, spamming on behalf of advertisers. All communication is pull-based—initiated by the subscriber.

Y! India Mobile currently has tie-ups with all leading Indian cellular operators in India including Airtel, Hutch, RPG, Escotel, Oasis and Spice Telecom.

Yahoo! India uses its short code 8243, to power advertiser's SMS responses. Pull-based marketing invites the customer to participate, and it is non-intrusive.

Yahoo! aids a variety of marketers (ESPN, Pepsi, and Motorola to name a few) to establish an SMS-based communication link with subscribers. And these clients have reported 50 to 60 per cent conversions on sales leads using the SMS medium.



Is SMS MARKE

Indian corporates wanting to exploit new media to reach out to customers, are increasingly relying on SMS to market products. How do they keep the line that divides marketing from spam?



Photographs: Mxy, Xavier, Imagin, Atul, Deshmukh



Jayant Khosla
CEO, Bharti Cellular Ltd.
Mumbai Circle

“Airtel uses SMS marketing to promote its own services and products—informing the customers of new offers and value added services. SMS targets audiences who are difficult to reach through traditional media channels. The conversion rates are as high as 80 to 90 per cent.

Over 1 million text messages are sent every month, and SMS messages are always read, making SMS a highly personal communication tool. They can also be timed, to achieve maximum impact.

Proper profiling is a must. For example, if we want to communicate to young women about attractive schemes, we use our database to customise our message to suit her needs.

Mobile marketing is at a nascent stage in India. Though there are no official figures regarding SMS, according to industry estimates, approximately 2 billion SMSs were exchanged among Indian consumers in 2003. This is much below the international average.

At Airtel, we don't intend to exploit our services as a medium to generate additional revenue, but we are open to the idea of providing our customers with value-added services.

We are conscious of the difference between spamming and providing information. Messages that we pass on have information that our subscribers can make use of.